

Cyber Threat Intelligence Advisory

Handala (Void Manticore): Abuse of Microsoft Intune for Enterprise-Scale Device Wiping

Traffic Light Protocol (TLP): AMBER

Analyst: Nora Asrar

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Purpose: Analysis of identity-based attacks leveraging Microsoft Intune to conduct enterprise-scale destructive operations.

This advisory was independently prepared using publicly available reporting for portfolio and educational purposes.

Executive Summary (BLUF)

Handala, also tracked as Void Manticore and BANISHED KITTEN, has shifted from deploying custom destructive malware to abusing trusted cloud administration platforms. The group has reportedly leveraged compromised privileged identities to issue enterprise-scale remote wipe commands through Mobile Device Management (MDM) platforms such as Microsoft Intune [1][2].

This activity reflects a broader shift toward abusing legitimate cloud administration tools rather than deploying traditional malware. With this approach, attackers are able to leverage trusted administrative functions to achieve destructive effects while reducing reliance on malicious software that traditional endpoint defenses are designed to detect. As a result, effective detection increasingly depends on monitoring privileged identities and cloud administration activity alongside traditional endpoint telemetry.

Threat Actor Profile

Attribution & Operational Model

Public reporting has linked Handala to actors associated with the Iranian Ministry of Intelligence and Security (MOIS) [1][3]. While the group presents itself as an independent hacktivist collective, threat intelligence reporting has consistently linked its operations to Iranian state interests. Their attacks typically combine network intrusions with strategic information operations intended to maximize psychological impact, erode public trust, and disrupt critical services [1][3].

Geopolitical Context

Observed Target Sectors

- Healthcare & Medical Technology
- Defense Industrial Base (DIB)
- Energy & Telecommunications
- Government & Critical Infrastructures (MENA region and allied Western countries)

Attack Lifecycle & MITRE ATT&CK Mapping

Attack Phase	MITRE ATT&CK	Observed Activity
Initial Access	T1566 (Phishing) T1557 (Adversary-in-the-Middle) T1539 (Steal Web Session Cookie)	Adversary-in-the-Middle (AiTM) phishing to bypass multi-factor authentication (MFA) and harvest authenticated session tokens [2]
Persistence & Privilege Escalation	T1098 (Account Manipulation) T1087 (Account Discovery) T1003 (OS Credential Dumping)	Active Directory enumeration via ADRecon, LSASS credential dumping, and rogue Global Administrator role assignments in Entra ID [2]

Execution & Impact	T1651 (Software Deployment Tools) T1485 (Data Destruction)	Automated script loops issuing Microsoft Graph API <code>managedDevice: wipe</code> requests across the tenant [2][4]
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Technical & Tactical Telemetry (Log-Hunting Guidance)

Detection should focus on cloud audit logs rather than endpoint telemetry. Security Operations Centers (SOCs) should prioritize monitoring the following data sources:

(1) Entra ID Audit Logs (`AuditLogs`)

- **Privileged Role Escalation:** Monitor for `Add member to role` events targeting critical administrative roles such as `Global Administrator` and `Intune Service Administrator`.
- **Session Anomalies:** Look for token usage originating from new ASN/IP spaces immediately following an MFA completion (`AiTM` cookie re-use).

(2) Microsoft Intune Audit Logs (`IntuneAuditLogs`)

- **Bulk Device Wipe Activity:** Alert on high-frequency spikes in `wipe managedDevice` or `retire managedDevice` operations.
- **User-Agent Anomalies:** Flag administrative actions originating from automated `PowerShell` sessions or unapproved API clients rather than standard Microsoft admin portals.

(3) Microsoft Graph Activity Logs (`MicrosoftGraphActivityLogs`)

- **API Endpoint Abuse:** Detect high-volume `POST` requests directed at:
`https://graph.microsoft.com/v1.0/deviceManagement/managedDevices/{managedDeviceId}/wipe`

Analyst Assessment

This campaign reflects an important shift in how Iranian cyber operators conduct destructive operations. By compromising privileged identities and abusing trusted administrative platforms such as Microsoft Intune, attackers can use legitimate enterprise capabilities to cause widespread disruption all while making their actions resemble authorized administrative activity.

As organizations continue adopting cloud-based identity and device management platforms, privileged accounts have become increasingly valuable targets. A single compromised administrative identity can provide access to capabilities that affect an entire managed environment. As a result, effective defense requires monitoring identities and administrative activity with the same level of attention traditionally given to endpoints.

Key Assessment

Organizations should assume that cloud administration platforms are attractive targets and prioritize controls that reduce both the likelihood and potential impact of privileged identity compromise.

Recommended Defensive Actions

(1) Restrict High-Risk Administrative Actions

Require Just-in-Time (JIT) privileged access and multi-admin approval for destructive actions, including device wipes. Microsoft and Deepwatch recommend these controls as safeguards against unauthorized or malicious use of Microsoft Intune administrative privileges [2][6].

(2) Enhance Behavioral Monitoring

Develop SIEM detections for anomalous management platform activity, including:

- Large volumes of remote wipe requests
- Sudden increases in Microsoft Graph API activity
- Administrative actions originating from unusual locations or impossible travel scenarios
- New privileged role assignments immediately preceding management actions

(3) Strengthen Identity Security

Implement phishing-resistant authentication for all privileged accounts using hardware-backed FIDO2 security keys or equivalent phishing-resistant MFA methods. Reduce standing administrative privileges through role-based access control and Privileged Identity Management (PIM), limiting the impact of compromised administrative credentials [2].

(4) Improve Incident Response Readiness

Establish documented procedures for responding to cloud identity compromise, including rapid credential revocation, privileged account containment, conditional access policy enforcement, and recovery of managed devices following unauthorized administrative actions.

Key Takeaways

- Management-plane abuse turns trusted enterprise software into a destructive weapon.
- Compromised cloud identities can create broad operational impacts that bypass traditional EDR controls.
- Detection strategies must shift toward monitoring identity telemetry and API activity.

References

- [1] Check Point Research. (2026, March 12). "Handala Hack" - Unveiling Group's Modus Operandi. research.checkpoint.com
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- [3] MITRE ATT&CK. (2026). VOID MANTICORE (G1055). attack.mitre.org
- [4] Microsoft Learn. (2026). managedDevice: wipe action - Microsoft Graph v1.0. learn.microsoft.com
- [5] Microsoft Learn. (2026). Device actions in Microsoft Intune. learn.microsoft.com
- [6] Microsoft Learn. Use access policies to require multi-admin approval in Microsoft Intune. learn.microsoft.com

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